Reach for the Top

The big idea

Two inspiring profiles of women who reached the top through grit. **Part I**: **Santosh Yadav**, the only woman in the world to climb **Mount Everest twice** (in the time described in the chapter). **Part II**: **Maria Sharapova**, a Russian girl who became world number one in tennis by the age of eighteen.

Part I: Santosh Yadav

- Born in **Joniyawas**, a village in **Rewari district, Haryana**, as the sixth child and only daughter after five sons, in a society where daughters were not usually welcomed.
- She refused to accept traditional roles: she wore shorts instead of traditional dress, and at 16, when pushed to marry, insisted on education. She went to school in **Delhi** by herself, paying fees through part-time jobs.
- Later at **Maharani College, Jaipur**, she watched villagers climbing the **Aravalli hills**, joined them, and then enrolled at the **Nehru Institute of Mountaineering, Uttarkashi**.
- She climbed Everest in **May 1992**, aged about twenty, becoming the **youngest woman** to do so then. On that climb she **shared her oxygen** with a fellow climber, **Mohan Singh**, saving his life.
- In **May 1993** she climbed again with an **Indo-Nepalese Women's Expedition** — the only woman to scale Everest twice.
- She unfurled the **Indian tricolour** on top and felt a sacred, spiritual moment. She also **collected and brought down about 500 kg of garbage**, showing environmental concern. She received the **Padma Shri**.

SANTOSH YADAV FACTS

Joniyawas (Haryana) · Uttarkashi institute · Everest 1992 and 1993 · saved Mohan Singh · 500 kg garbage · Padma Shri.

Part II: Maria Sharapova

- Born in **Siberia, Russia** (1987). At **nine**, she went to the **USA (Florida)** with her father to train in tennis. Her mother could not join them for two years because of **visa** restrictions.
- She was lonely, younger than other trainees who bullied her, but she made her loneliness into **determination**.
- By **18** she had become **world number one** in women's tennis. She won Wimbledon at 17 (2004).
- She is proud of being **Russian**. She loves fashion, singing, dancing and reading **Arthur Conan Doyle**.
- Her secret: willingness to sacrifice; "If you're willing to sacrifice, you will get there."

Themes

- **Determination, hard work and sacrifice**.
- **Breaking gender stereotypes** (Santosh).
- **Compassion and responsibility** (saving a climber, cleaning Everest).

NOT "FIRST WOMAN TO CLIMB EVEREST"

Santosh Yadav was the first woman to climb Everest **twice**, not the first woman ever (that was Junko Tabei, 1975).

LIKELY QUESTIONS

How was Santosh different from other girls of her village? What instances show her concern for others and the environment? What qualities helped Sharapova succeed? Compare the two women.

Quick recap

- Santosh Yadav: rebellious, educated herself, Everest twice, saved a life, cleaned garbage.
- Maria Sharapova: left Russia at 9, lonely years in the USA, world no. 1 at 18.
- Common qualities: grit, focus, sacrifice.

Practice questions

1. Santosh Yadav was born in a village in which state?
   (a) Rajasthan (b) Haryana (c) Uttarakhand (d) Himachal Pradesh
2. Where did Santosh Yadav train in mountaineering?
   (a) Darjeeling (b) Manali (c) Uttarkashi (d) Jaipur
3. What did Santosh Yadav do for her fellow climber Mohan Singh?
   (a) Carried him down the mountain (b) Shared her oxygen with him (c) Gave him her tent (d) Called a rescue helicopter
4. What made Santosh Yadav unique among climbers in 1993?
   (a) She was the first Indian to climb Everest (b) She was the only woman to have climbed Everest twice (c) She climbed without oxygen (d) She climbed alone
5. At what age did Maria Sharapova leave for the USA?
   (a) Six (b) Nine (c) Twelve (d) Fifteen
6. Why could Sharapova's mother not accompany her to the USA?
   (a) She was ill (b) She did not like tennis (c) Visa restrictions (d) She had to look after a younger child
7. How did Santosh Yadav show her concern for the environment?
8. Compare Santosh Yadav and Maria Sharapova. What qualities did they share?

Answers: 1. b 2. c 3. b 4. b 5. b 6. c 7. see notes 8. see notes